

Lessons Learned

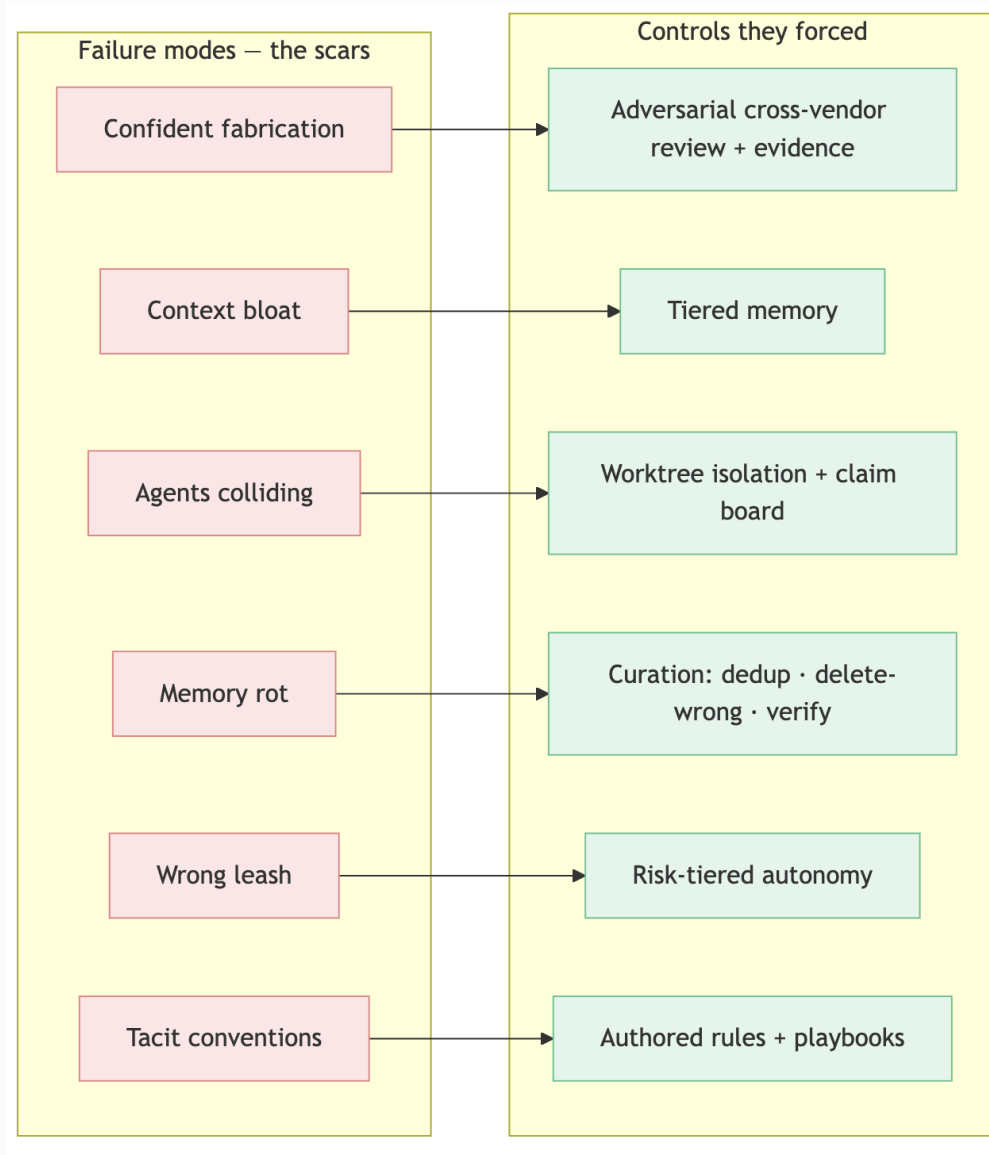
Every control is a scar

What broke — and what each break forced us to build.

The framing

- None of this was **designed up front**. It **accreted** — each control added *after* something broke.
- The clean architecture you've seen is the **scar tissue**.

“ This is the honest version: not the system, but the failures that built it. ”



Scar — "it lied to us, convincingly"

- An agent reported tests **green**, the bug **fixed**, the task **done** — fluently and **wrongly**.
- We caught it by **luck**. Then we stopped relying on luck.

|“ → **control:** adversarial cross-vendor review + **evidence before assertion**. ”

Scar — "more memory made it dumber"

- The instinct: give the agent **everything** it knows.
- The result: **slower, costlier, less focused** — drowning in its own context.

|“ → **control:** tiered memory — tiny always-on index, the rest on demand.

”

Scar — "parallel agents destroyed each other's work"

- Several agents on **one checkout** clobbered files, branches, build state.
- **Speed turned into corruption.**

|“ → **control:** worktree isolation + a claim board.

”

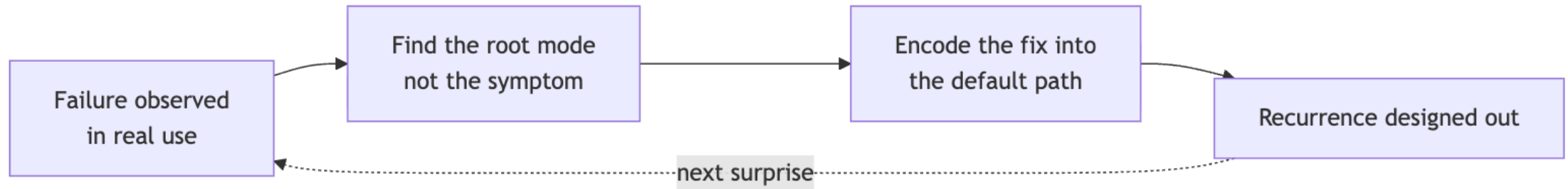
...and three more, same shape

- **Memory rot** — the knowledge base decayed into a stale, contradictory wiki. → *curation: dedup · delete-wrong · verify*
- **Wrong leash** — too autonomous on risky work, too gated on safe work. → *risk-tiered autonomy*
- **Tacit conventions** — re-explaining the same rules every session. → *authored rules + playbooks*

Cross-cutting law 1

Plausible-but-wrong is the *default*, not the exception.

- With agents, **fluent and confident says nothing about correct.**
- Trust nothing unproven — assume the gap is there until evidence closes it.



Cross-cutting laws 2 & 3

- **(2) Discipline doesn't survive on willpower – encode it.** Anything that relies on *remembering* gets skipped under deadline.
- **(3) Curation is forever.** Memory, rules, boards all rot – weeding is ongoing, not setup.

What the scars add up to

The "system" is just the **accumulated answer to 'what broke.'**

“ *Honest caveat:* you can't **cargo-cult** the controls without the failures. Copy the worktrees and the review gate but skip the **discipline**, and you get the overhead without the protection. ”

Close

"We didn't design a system. We kept fixing what broke, and wrote down why."

That is the system.